Airtribe

Product Management Launchpad

Week- 2

Product Management Roadmap

PHASE 1
CRAFT
Modules 1–4

1. Fundamentals of Product Management
2. Product Strategy & Strategic Thinking
   WEEK 2
3. Problem Discovery, Market & User Research
4. Problem Framing & Prioritization

PHASE 2
CRAFT + AI
Modules 5–8

5. UX & Design Collaboration
6. Effective Communication as a PM
7. Analytics & Metrics
8. Product Launch, Growth & Monetization

PHASE 3
DEEP AI
Modules 9–13

9. Tech 101 & System Design
10. LLMs, RAGs & AI Foundations
11. Vibe Coding for PMs
12. Agentic AI & AI Systems in Production
13. Capstone Project & Interview Prep

Product Strategy & Strategic Thinking

Week 2

From shipping features to making **strategic choices**.

A product leader decides where **to play**, **how to win**, and **what not to do**.



What are we looking at today: Session 1

From direction to defensible choices.

1. Product strategy: vision, mission, positioning.



2. Competitive moats and market positioning.



3. Systems thinking: second-order effects and feedback loops.



4. Bet sizing and resource allocation.



5. B2B strategy patterns.



6. Q&A.







By the end of this session, you should be able to separate strategy from planning and defend a strategic choice.

Vision, mission, strategy, roadmap

They are connected, but they answer different questions.

1 Vision



What future are we trying to create?

2 Mission



What problem do we exist to solve, and for whom?

3 Strategy



Where will we play, how will we win, and what will we not do?

4 Roadmap



Which bets ship first, in what sequence, and when?



Strong PMs do not confuse aspiration, choice, and execution.

What great product managers actually do

Strategy is about making consequential choices under uncertainty.

1. Define direction beyond the roadmap



2. Evaluate positioning and moats



3. Size bets and allocate resources



4. Think in systems, not isolated features



Strategy ≠ Roadmap

Product managers separate direction from delivery.

1 Vision



future state

2 Strategy



choices and trade-offs

3 Bets



big initiatives

4 Roadmap



sequence and timing

Vision sets the destination

Strategy decides what matters

Roadmaps schedule the work

If the feature list changes and the story still works, you probably did not have a strategy.

Strategy is a set of choices

A product leader decides where to play, how to win, and what not to do.

1. **Vision** gives direction.



2. **Positioning** defines the market you serve.



3. **Moats** protect your advantage.



4. **Resource allocation** turns strategy into action.



A roadmap lists work. **Strategy explains why the work matters.**

Where to play

Good strategy starts by narrowing the field.

1 Customer segment



Who has the sharpest pain and the highest willingness to change?

2 Use case / job



Which job matters enough to become a habit?

3 Category / market



Which frame helps customers understand why we matter?

4 Channel / geography



Where can we reach, onboard, and win efficiently?



Who hurts most? | Where is urgency highest? | Where can we win first?

How to win

Winning is not being everywhere. It is being meaningfully better on something that matters.

1 Better product experience



Faster, simpler, more reliable, or more delightful.

2 Better economics



Create clearer ROI, lower cost, or a stronger business model.

3 Better distribution



Reach demand that competitors cannot reach as effectively.

4 Better workflow fit



Become part of the customer's natural way of working.

We win by delivering a superior outcome for a clear segment in a way competitors cannot easily match.

Positioning and moats

Choose the customer, the promise, and the advantage you can defend.

1. Choose the customer.



2. Choose the promise.



3. Choose the differentiator.



Build moats that compound.



For [segment], our product delivers [value] because [differentiator].

- Why this customer?
- Why this promise?
- What cannot be copied easily?

Moats that actually matter

A moat is an advantage that compounds as the product scales.

1



Distribution

Reach customers faster or cheaper than others can.

2



Data

Usage creates insight, personalization, and product improvement.

3



Workflow switching cost

The product becomes embedded in how work gets done.

4



Network effects

More users create more value for every participant.

5



Brand / trust

Trust reduces decision friction and improves conversion.

A feature can be copied. A compounding system is harder to copy.

Systems thinking: watch loops, not lines

Great PMs optimize the system, not a single screen.

See second-order effects

Today's change can create tomorrow's results.

Watch incentives

People respond to incentives, not announcements.



Fix bottlenecks, not symptoms

Improve constraints to unlock the whole system.

Measure the whole system

Use leading and lagging metrics across the loop.

Leaders improve loops, not isolated features.

First-order vs second-order effects

The immediate outcome is obvious. The strategic outcome is usually delayed.

Example: lower seller onboarding friction

1 First-order effect

More sellers sign up



2 Second-order effect

Selection improves



3 System effect

Buyer conversion rises



4 Business outcome

GMV and retention improve



What to watch

Behavior change, not just feature launch.

What to avoid

Optimizing a local metric while harming the wider system.

Good PMs ask what happens next, and then what happens after that.

Bet sizing and resource allocation

Product leaders fund conviction in stages.

Evaluate every bet through this framework

Upside	Confidence	Reversibility	Time to signal
What is the upside?	What evidence exists?	Is the bet reversible?	How long until we learn?



Strong strategy is not just choosing the bet.
It is choosing how much to risk, and when.

Bet sizing

Not every opportunity deserves the same capital.

High

Upside

Low

Low

Confidence

High

2 Pilot

High upside,
low confidence.
Learn before scaling.



1 Big bet

High upside,
high confidence.
Commit talent
and time.



4 Avoid

Low upside,
low confidence.
Do not distract
the team.



3 Optimize

Low upside,
high confidence.
Improve
efficiently.



Confidence comes from

- Usage depth
- Retention
- Customer pull
- Willingness to pay

Stage investment: learn small, scale only when the signal improves.

When to kill, hold, or double down

Resource allocation is a repeated decision, not a yearly memo.

1 Kill



- Weak signal
- Rising cost
- No strategic fit

2 Hold



- Signal is mixed
- Need more evidence
- Decision is reversible

3 Double down



- Usage is deep
- Economics are improving
- The bet strengthens the moat

Evaluate every bet on | Usage depth | Retention | Revenue quality | Strategic fit

Live Activity — Strategy Breakdown

Pick a product you use every week.

Product:

Blinkit



10-minute delivery of daily essentials

1 Target Segment

Who is this built for?

2 Wedge

Why do users start?

3 Moat

What gets stronger over time?

4 Current Bet

Where are they doubling down?

5 Stop Doing

What should they cut?

Session 1 Recap

Turn the framework into a product diagnosis.

1. Separate strategy from roadmap



2. Choose where to play



3. Define how to win



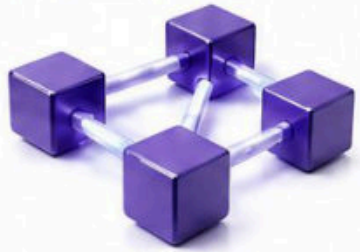
4. Build moats that compound



5. Size bets with discipline



6. Think in systems, not isolated features





Good PMs form opinions and defend them with evidence.

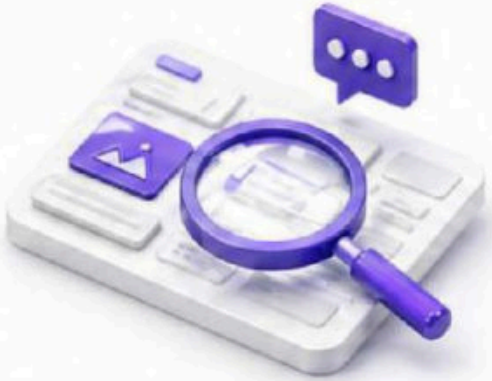
Session 2 | Product Judgment, Operating Models, and Strategic Interviews

How product leaders make better calls under uncertainty.



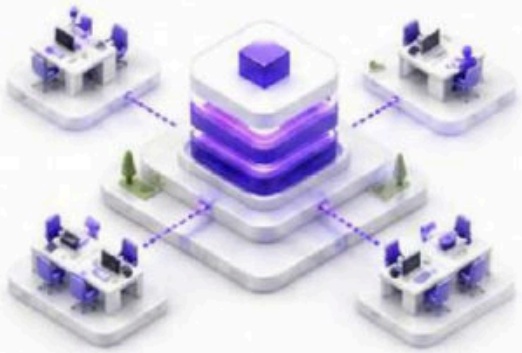
Product judgment & taste

Know what good looks like and why it wins.



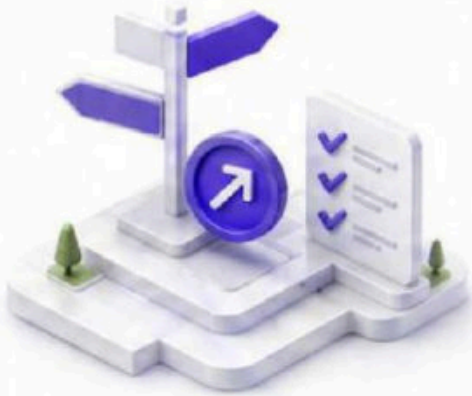
Teardowns & opinion building

Critique products with evidence, not vibes.



The new PM operating model

Smaller teams, higher agency, faster learning.



Strategic thinking in interviews

Structure ambiguity, choose trade-offs, defend decisions.

What would a leader notice? | What should we believe? | What would we choose?

What are we looking at today: Session 2

From operating model to strategic interview clarity.

1. How the PM role is changing.



2. AI-first PM operating models.



3. Product x design x engineering.



4. Product judgment and taste.



5. Interview answer structure.



6. Case walkthrough + Q&A.





By the end of this session, you should be able to think like a product leader, **defend strategic opinions, and structure strong interview answers.**



Break Out Room Assignment - 35 mins



You are a Product Manager at **DailyDish - A consumer company building a recipe discovery and meal planning app**, in a space where products like Tasty, Yummly, and Mealime already exist.

The current product allows users to browse recipes, save favorites, and create weekly meal plans. Downloads are strong because people enjoy discovering new recipes, but most users stop using the app after a few days.

Many users save recipes they never cook, create meal plans they never follow, and eventually return to old cooking habits.

Leadership believes there is an opportunity to build a product that becomes a daily companion in helping people decide what to eat, shop efficiently, cook consistently, and reduce food waste.

Your task is to define a product strategy that turns this into a habit-forming, high-retention consumer product.

Common strategy mistakes

Most weak strategies fail for predictable reasons.

1 Confusing roadmap with strategy

A list of features is not a choice about where to win.

2 Serving everyone

Broad targeting weakens positioning.

3 No moat thinking

Value that does not compound is easy to copy.

4 Scaling too early

Big bets without evidence waste resources.

5 Optimizing local metrics

A short-term win can damage the wider system.



Great product leaders reduce strategic error before they increase output.

Choice over activity | Focus over breadth | Evidence over hope

B2B strategy: point solution vs platform

The wedge gets you in. The workflow keeps you in.

1 Point solution



- Solves one acute pain
- Fast ROI, easier adoption
- Clear wedge, lower switching cost

2 Platform



- Owns a broader workflow
- Shared data across modules
- Higher ACV and stronger switching cost

3 Land-and-expand



Win one team, prove value, expand seats, workflows, and modules over time.

What is the wedge? | What expands naturally? | Where does data com

How the PM role is changing

In small, high-agency teams, PMs create leverage through decisions, clarity, and speed.

1. **Product judgment** — Sharper calls on what matters.

2. **Builder fluency** — Work closely with design, engineering, and AI tools.



3. **Business sense** — Connect product choices to growth, retention, and revenue.

4. **Team leverage** — Remove ambiguity so the team can move faster.

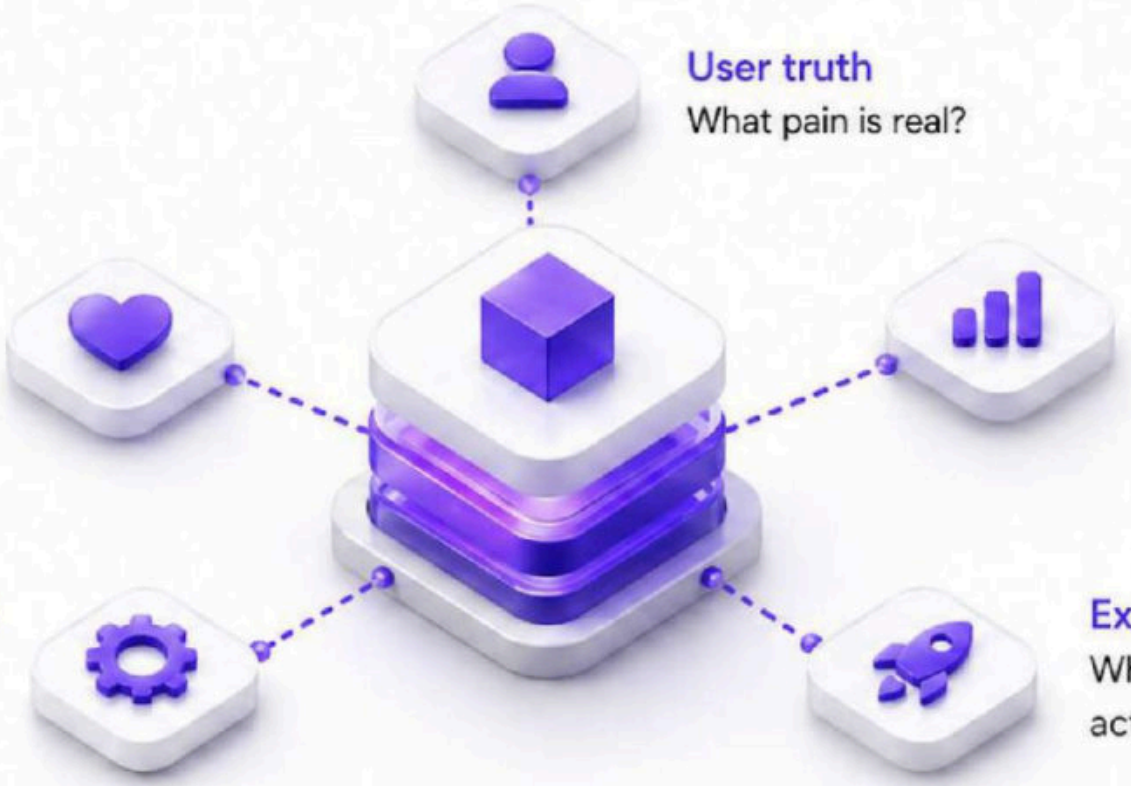
Less of this | Status reporting, passive coordination, feature brokering

More of this | Decision-making, synthesis, prioritization, and quality bar setting

Judge better | Clarify faster | Raise team leverage

Product judgment and taste

Judgment is choosing well with incomplete information. Taste is knowing what good looks like before the data is perfect.



User truth
What pain is real?

Product intuition
What experience feels obvious?

Market context
Why now?

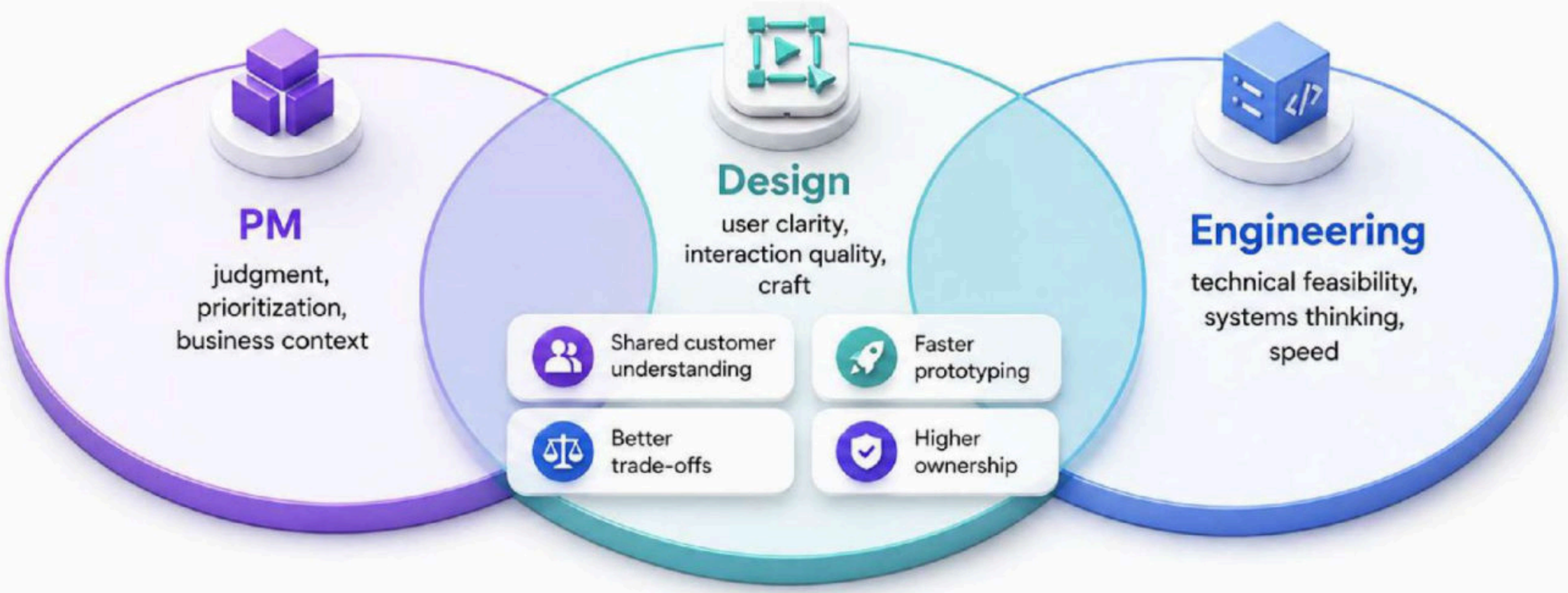
Business logic
How does it create durable value?

Execution realism
What can the team actually ship well?

Great product leaders do not just ask what users want. They judge what is worth building, for whom, and why it should win.

PM, design, and engineering convergence

Great product teams still have clear roles, but the overlap is growing.



The strongest PMs can collaborate across functions without pretending to replace them.

The new PM operating model

AI and better tools are compressing teams and raising the bar for judgment.

Before

- Larger teams, slower handoffs
- PM as coordinator
- Research, design, and execution more siloed
- Learning cycles measured in weeks



Now

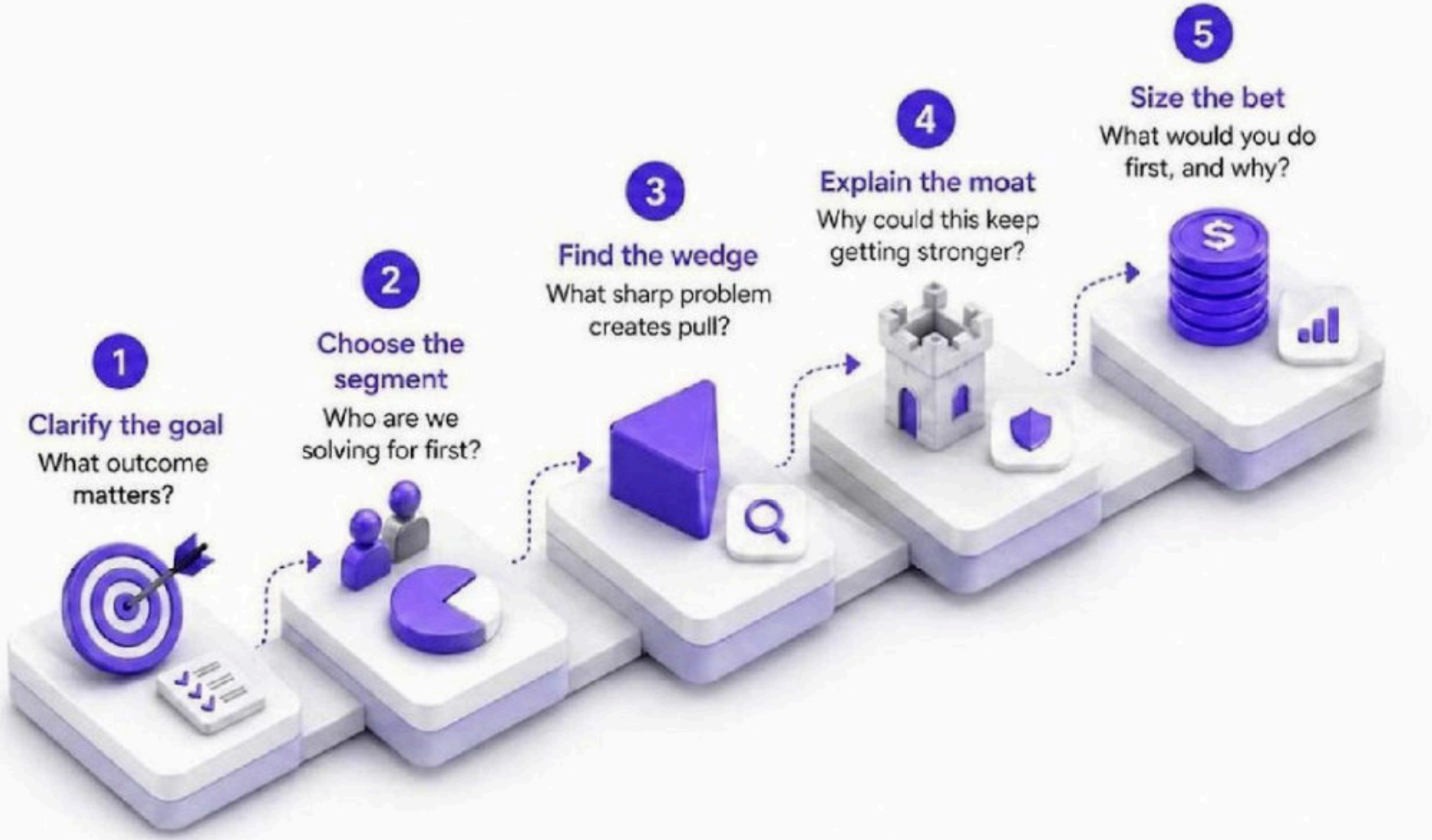
- Smaller teams, higher agency
- PM as decision-maker and builder-partner
- PM, design, and engineering work closer together
- Learning cycles measured in days



As **leverage** increases, the edge shifts from output to **judgment**.

Strategic thinking in interviews

Interviewers are testing how you structure ambiguity and choose trade-offs.



1
Clarify the goal
What outcome matters?

2
Choose the segment
Who are we solving for first?

3
Find the wedge
What sharp problem creates pull?

4
Explain the moat
Why could this keep getting stronger?

5
Size the bet
What would you do first, and why?

What great answers show

- structured thinking
- customer understanding
- trade-off awareness
- business judgment

Strategy Case Rubric: How a Product Manager Answers

Interviewers are testing judgment under ambiguity, not whether you know a framework name.

1 Clarify the goal

Which outcome matters: growth, retention, revenue, quality, or risk?

2 Choose the segment

Who is the sharpest user or buyer to solve for first?

3 Name the trade-off

What will you not do, delay, or intentionally ignore?

4 Defend the bet

Why this path now? What evidence supports it?

5 Define success

What leading metric, guardrail, and learning signal will you track?

Answer pattern

Goal → segment → choice → trade-off → metric.

! **A strong answer is structured, commercial, and opinionated, but still testable.**

Take Home Assignment

LearnForward
LEARN. GROW. SUCCEED TOGETHER.

You are the **first Product Manager at a B2B SaaS company building a product in the corporate learning and employee training platform** space.

Your task is to define a clear product strategy for the next 2/3 years.

1. Identifying specific customer segment you want to target first (for example: startups, mid-sized companies, or enterprises).

2. Define how big this opportunity is? how frequently one use this? how painful it is? and why customers would be willing to pay for a better solution?

3. Select the **core problem you want to solve deeply**

4. Think about **moats**. Explain what defensibility you can build over time, this could be through data, integrations, network effects (IT, employees, HR teams), switching costs, or brand. Be specific about how your product becomes harder to replace as it scales.

Take Home Assignment

5.Describe your **land and expand strategy.** How will you enter a company with a small, easy-to-adopt use case, and then grow your footprint across teams, departments, or use cases? Think about who your initial buyer is, how you create internal pull, and what triggers expansion.

Do not jump into features immediately. Focus on clarity of thinking: what problem you are solving, for whom, why it matters, and how it scales into a durable business.

Module 2 recap: how product managers think strategically

Strategy is a chain of choices — about where to play, how to win, and what to ignore.

1. **Vision & positioning**
   Choose the customer and the promise.
2. **Moats**
   Build advantages that compound.
3. **Systems thinking**
   See second-order effects.
4. **Bet sizing**
   Fund conviction in stages.



5. **B2B strategy**
   Wedge, workflow, expansion.
6. **Product judgment**
   Turn taste into reasoned opinion.
7. **New PM operating model**
   High agency, small teams, sharper decisions.
8. **Interview thinking**
   Frame clearly, choose decisively, explain trade-offs.

Choose | Differentiate | Compound | Decide

Q & A